

Germany's far-right AfD: Proxies for Trump and Russia

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02/24/2025

The far-right Alternative for Germany (AfD) wants to have a bigger say in foreign policy. It is relying on its contacts within the Trump administration in the US to help it exert pressure on the government in Germany.



The AfD has traditionally been close to Russia, but more recently it has received support from the United States
Image: Julian Stratenschulte/dpa/picture alliance

Fears, doomsday scenarios and conspiracy theories are the lifeblood of the far-right [Alternative for Germany party \(AfD\)](#).

When it became clear on election night (February 23, 2025) that the far-right party would achieve a historic victory in [the federal elections](#), but with their result of just over 20% would come in in second rather than first place, the comment sections on social media went into overdrive: "Election fraud!", "Good night, Germany!", "We're all going to die", "Last resort: Trump!".

AfD supporters believe that Germany, the world's third-largest economy, is on the brink and has been for years, if not decades. To bring about change, they are calling for Trump-style "Germany first" policymaking.

Donald Trump, the AfD and conspiracy theorists

Jürgen Elsässer is an ardent supporter of US President [Donald Trump](#). He is also a fervent conspiracy theorist. Elsässer used to be a left-wing extremist. Today, he is an extreme right-wing media entrepreneur and influential AfD campaign supporter with his publishing house Compact.

[Efforts to ban Compact are currently underway](#) in the German courts. It disseminates "antisemitic, racist, anti-minority, historical revisionism and conspiracy theory content," according to Germany's Interior Ministry. The AfD's candidate for chancellor and co-chair of the party [Alice Weidel](#) has called the move to ban the publication a "serious blow to the freedom of the press."

On election Sunday, Elsässer hosted a three-hour live broadcast on YouTube channel Compact TV which has over 475,000 subscribers. According to Elsässer, war is coming to Germany and [Friedrich Merz](#), leader of the conservative [Christian Democrats \(CDU\)](#) and likely next chancellor, is responsible.

During the live broadcast, Elsässer proffered a solution for Germany: "Perhaps we need a temporary occupation by the peace powers, the US and Russia." A former AfD member of the [Bundestag](#) seconded the proposal, elaborating that the so-called enemy state clause from [World War II](#) is still applicable because it allows the former victorious powers, Russia and the US, "to intervene politically and militarily in Germany without a [UN Security Council](#) resolution if they are convinced that the political situation is becoming unstable."

Common friends, common enemies

Today's far right see Trump and Russian dictator [Vladimir Putin](#) as the saviors of the German nation. And even if the talk of a two-front war and myriad conspiracy theories bear little relationship to reality, the resonance of such narratives can have an impact on the real world. As the 2025 federal elections have shown, many people in Germany have fears and anxieties about the future, and that includes the prospect of war.

The day after the election, Weidel talked up cooperation with the US, Russia and China who she referred to as "partners." With her new contacts to the Trump administration Elon Musk and US Vice President JD Vance, both of whom supported her election campaign, Weidel suggested the AfD could simply bypass any future German government on foreign policy. "We are the point of contact for our negotiating partners on the international stage," she explained confidently.

Although the AfD will likely be shut out of any coalition government, foreign policy pressure from within could still pose a challenge for the future chancellor. "The Trump administration has no interest in maintaining Europe as a strong player. Their approach seems to be that supporting radical nationalists weakens the European Union," Boris Vormann, a political scientist at Bard College Berlin, told DW.

Given what Vormann calls its "ideological proximity" to the Trump administration, the AfD could well become an instrument for the US to undermine the authority of the German government. "There is a common understanding of what is wrong with society, for example, a rejection of wokeness and support for a traditional family image and conservative values," Vormann said.

And like Donald Trump, the AfD has a certain admiration for Vladimir Putin and Russia. "Today it is a country that is not only associated with negative connotations, but one or two people also hope that it could be the champion of a world of free and sovereign states without hegemonic influence," enthused Björn Höcke, one of the most influential AfD politicians, in an interview in January 2023.

The fact that Putin is waging a bloody [war of aggression in Ukraine](#) that has killed tens of thousands of people is not an issue for the AfD. Nor is the fact that the Trump administration is running roughshod over the rule of law. The AfD wants to present itself as an equally powerful force on the world stage. Should the conflicts between Europe and the US or Russia escalate, they hope to position themselves as a viable alternative on foreign policy.

The AfD wants to become the biggest political force in Germany and hopes that by putting pressure on the conservatives it can drive the political agenda. On

election night, Weidel was already talking about the 2029 federal elections when she said the AfD would "have a mandate to govern."

Political scientists agree that generating fear and anxiety ultimately benefits the far right, a lesson the AfD and its media cheerleaders appear to know only too well.

This article was originally written in German.

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